DOKLAM STANDOFF BETWEEN INDIA AND CHINA

The Doklam plateau is a geo-strategically significant area, as it is located in the tri-junction of Bhutan-China-India, overlooking the Chumbi valley and lying between the two Silk road entry points from China to India—the Nathu La and Jelep La. The Doklam became a point of rift between the two big neighbours— India and China— following China's attempts to construct a paved road which will be able to carry vehicles up to 50 tonnes. This move is like a threat to the security of Siliguri Corridor or the 'Chicken's Neck', and once the project is completed it would be able to empower China to cut-off the north-eastern states from the rest of India by blocking the narrow bottleneck region of Siliguri Corridor.

Doklam has been a contended territory between Bhutan and China and the two has entered into an agreement by which both agreed to maintain a status quo in Doklam. China objected to India's intervention in the Doklam row. India however, clarified its position and said that it had acted upon the request of Bhutan as per the 2007 Friendship Treaty. The Doklam row almost led to collision of two giant neighbours and the crisis lasted for about a little over two months. It was like an eye-ball-to eyeball confrontation. Ultimately, in the sidelines of BRICS Summit in September 2017, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping met, and both the leaders vowed to move forward in ties, and also decided to boost military cooperation to avoid future confrontation. Japan had asked China to maintain the status quo at Doklam. This infuriated China, but Indo-Japan strategic relationship can see a new upsurge in the future. Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe's visit to India in September 2017 carries a positive message in that direction.